

How does a magnet work?

Magnets are usually made of a metal called iron, or metal that contains iron. Magnets attract (pull in) things made of iron, or other magnetic metals. All magnets have two ends—a north pole and a south pole.

North pole

This end of the magnet is the north pole. If it meets a north pole on another magnet, it pushes it away, but if it meets a south pole on another magnet, it attracts it (pulls toward it).

Magnetic field

Lines of magnetic force (the power that attracts magnetic metals) connect the two poles. The pattern of these lines is called the magnetic field.

Quick quiz



Which metal are magnets made from?



What are the ends of a magnet called?



What invention uses a magnet?

Iron pattern

If tiny specks of iron, called filings, are sprinkled around a magnet, they follow the pattern of its magnetic field.

Bar magnet

Magnetic force loops

